

General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Indian Handicrafts



INDIAN HANDICRAFTS



Handicrafts

- **Handicrafts** are all the items made by a man's or woman's hands. Indian handicrafts encapsulate the essence of Indian culture, beauty, and richness of Indian heritage.
- Many **Indian states** have **distinct handicrafts** that demonstrate **creative ability and expertise**.
- Artists employ their **talent** to make a variety of items, both **ornamental and practical**.
- These crafts are **one-of-a-kind** since they are entirely handcrafted **without the aid of any machinery**.
- **Hastkala, hastshilp, dastkari, and karigari** are typical **Indian terminology** for handicrafts.
- All these terms indicate **workmanship** and refer to **products manufactured with craftsmanship**, i.e., specialised **hand skills** that are also beautiful.
- The **aesthetic element** of such products is an **integral aspect** of their worth, implying that the **object** of usefulness has a value that extends **beyond its utility** and is also **attractive to the sight**.

- A **handcrafted product** is rarely purely ornamental. Whether **unadorned** or heavily **embellished**, its real purpose is served only when it is **both functional and beautiful**.

Types of Handicrafts

The following are the **major types of Indian handicrafts** with distinct regional specialities:

Handicraft Type	Description
Glassware	It has a long history, with famous glass bangles from Hyderabad and Ferozabad .
Cloth Handicrafts	Includes Tie and Dye, Embroidery, Kalamkari, and Batik Art .
Ivory Carving	Traditional sculptures, combs, and ornaments ; centres in Jaipur, Jodhpur, and Delhi .
Terracotta Crafts	Sculptures and pottery made from baked clay; famous in Bankura (West Bengal) .
Silver Crafts	Renowned for filigree and Bidri work from Odisha and Karnataka .
Clay and Pottery Work	Traditional craft with roots in the Vedic period .
Bronze Crafts	Metal casting techniques dating back to Mohenjodaro .
Metal Crafts	Known for Marori work from Rajasthan .
Leather Products	Special items include camel leather bags and Kolhapuri chappals .
Wooden Work	Includes walnut furniture from Kashmir and Teakwood houses from Kerala .
Toy Making	Producing lacquered wood and papier-mâché toys .
Stoneware	Famous for intricate carvings at Ajanta, Ellora, and Khajuraho .
Embroidery Craft	Phulkari and Pipli embroidery from Punjab and Odisha .
Floor Designs	Regional arts such as Kolam, Rangoli, and Mandana .

Glassware

- **Glassmaking** in India, like other artisan traditions, has a **long history**.
- The **Mahabharata** refers to **glass**, but there is **no material evidence** of **glass beads** from the **Harappan civilization**.
- **The first evidence** comes from the **Painted Grey Ware culture (c. 1000 BC)** with **beautiful glass beads** found in the **Ganges Valley**.
- **The glass** was referred to as **kanch** or **kaca** in the **Vedic text Satapatha Brahmana**.
- **Glass archaeological evidence** was discovered in **southern India** at **Maski**, a Chalcolithic site in **Deccan**.
- **Glass bangles** are significant in **Indian jewellery history**.
 - The most beautiful ones are **Churikajodas** from **Hyderabad**.
 - **Ferozabad** in **Uttar Pradesh** is renowned for **glass bangles** and **utilitarian glassware**.

Table of Glassware Handicrafts in India

Glassware Handicraft	State	Feature
Churikajodas (Glass Bangles)	Hyderabad, Telangana	Known for their elegance and beauty, widely used as traditional jewellery.
Ferozabad Glass Bangles	Uttar Pradesh	Famous for a variety of colourful glass bangles, often used for both ornamental and daily wear.
Utilitarian Glassware	Ferozabad, Uttar Pradesh	Includes functional items like glass bottles, utensils, and decorative objects.
Glass Beads (Ancient Evidence)	Ganges Valley (Painted Grey Ware culture)	The earliest evidence of glass beads from around 1000 BC, used in jewellery and decoration.

Archaeological Glass (Maski)	Maski, Karnataka	Glass artefacts found at this Chalcolithic site, indicate the ancient use of glass in Deccan.
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Cloth Handicrafts

- **Cloth** is used in a variety of **techniques**, including **weaving** and **printing**.
- Artists create **patterns** using **wooden blocks** or **printed cloths**.
- **Tie and Dye** creates **beautiful designs** on fabrics through several techniques:
 - **Bandhani** or **Bandhej** is a **Tie and Dye** method prevalent in **Rajasthan and Gujarat**.
- **Kalamkari**: An **ancient process** of **hand-painting fabrics** with **vegetable dyes** is still widely used in **Andhra Pradesh**.
- **Batik Art**:
 - **Batik** involves using **molten wax** on one end of the fabric, and then dyeing it to produce **multicoloured designs**.
 - Popular in **Madhya Pradesh** and **West Bengal**.
- **Embroidery**:
 - **Elevated patterns** are created using **threads** or **wooden blocks** with **needles** and **gold, silver, silk, or cotton threads**.
- **Weaving**:
 - **Weaving** is the process of **interlacing yarn** to produce **textiles and fabrics**.
 - **Warp** refers to the **vertical thread**, while **weft** is the **horizontal thread**.
 - **Warp and weft threads** are usually interlaced in **fixed patterns** using a **loom**, producing different types of **weaves**.

Table of Cloth Handicrafts in India

Cloth Handicraft	State	Feature
Bandhani / Bandhej (Tie and Dye)	Rajasthan, Gujarat	Intricate tie and dye technique creating vibrant patterns on fabrics, often used in sarees and turbans.

Kalamkari	Andhra Pradesh	Hand-painted fabrics using natural vegetable dyes; often depict mythological and religious themes.
Batik Art	Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal	Fabric dyed with molten wax-resist technique to create multicoloured patterns on sarees and dupattas.
Chikankari Embroidery	Uttar Pradesh (Lucknow)	Delicate white thread embroidery on fine fabrics like muslin and cotton, is used for kurtas and sarees.
Kantha Stitch Embroidery	West Bengal, Odisha	Simple running stitch embroidery, used for quilts, stoles, and sarees with floral or animal motifs.
Phulkari Embroidery	Punjab, Haryana	Colourful floral embroidery on fabric using a darning stitch, typically used for dupattas and shawls.
Pipli Applique Work	Odisha	Applique technique where brightly coloured fabric pieces are stitched together to create decorative items.
Ikat Weaving	Telangana, Odisha	Yarn-dyed and woven into intricate patterns; often used in sarees and fabrics.
Patola Silk Weaving	Gujarat	Double-ikat weaving technique creating rich geometric designs; famous for Patola sarees.
Pashmina Weaving	Jammu and Kashmir	Fine wool fabric handwoven from Pashmina wool, known for shawls with intricate patterns.
Zari Work	Gujarat, Maharashtra	Gold or silver thread embroidery on silk fabrics, is used in sarees and ceremonial garments.

Kutch Embroidery	Gujarat	Heavily embroidered fabrics with mirror work, are commonly used in ethnic garments and home décor.
Toda Embroidery	Tamil Nadu (Nilgiris)	Red and black geometric embroidery on white fabric, traditionally used by the Toda tribe.
Bhagalpuri Silk Weaving	Bihar (Bhagalpur)	Known for producing Tussar silk sarees with natural textures and subtle patterns.
Chanderi Weaving	Madhya Pradesh (Chanderi)	Light silk and cotton blended fabrics with zari work, used for sarees and stoles.

Ivory Carving

- **Ivory carving** has been practiced since **Vedic times**, when **ivory** was known as **danta** (related to the **elephant's tusk**).
- **Trade routes** from the **Harappan period** show the movement of **ivory products** to **Turkmenistan, Afghanistan, and the Persian Gulf**.
- **Sanchi inscription (2 BCE)** refers to the **Vidisha guild of ivory workers** and mentions **ivory sculptures in the Sanchi Stupa**.
- Archaeological findings include **ivory combs** from **Taxila**.
- **Ivory art flourished** during the **Mughal period** with items like **combs, dagger handles, and ornaments**.
- Traditional centres:
 - **Kerala**: Known for **ivory paintings**.
 - **Jodhpur**: Famous for **ivory bangles**.
 - **Jaipur**: Known for **ivory jali work** (used in homes and art objects).

Table of Ivory Carving Handicrafts in India

Ivory Carving Handicraft	State	Feature
Ivory Jali Work	Jaipur, Rajasthan	Famous for intricate latticework, often used in decorative objects, windows, and furniture.

Ivory Bangles	Jodhpur, Rajasthan	Known for traditional and ceremonial ivory bangles, widely used in weddings and festivals.
Miniature Ivory Paintings	Kerala	Renowned for delicate, detailed miniature paintings on thin ivory sheets, popular in royal collections.
Ambari Hathi (Ivory Elephant)	West Bengal	Symbolic ivory-carved elephants representing royalty, are used in rituals and décor.
Ivory Combs	Delhi	Historical significance, used since ancient times, especially during the Mughal era.
Ivory Sculptures	Tamil Nadu	Famous for beautifully carved religious idols used in temples and homes.
Ivory Chess Sets	West Bengal	Exported globally, known for intricately carved chess pieces with unique designs.
Ivory Inlay Work	Karnataka	Famous for inlaying ivory into furniture and musical instruments, adding elegance and luxury.
Ivory Handles for Daggers	Mughal Centers (Delhi, Agra)	Exquisite dagger handles made from ivory were popular during the Mughal period for nobles and royalty.
Jewelry Boxes and Caskets	Rajasthan, Delhi	Beautifully designed ivory boxes are used for storing jewellery and artefacts, often gifted at royal events.

Terracotta Crafts

- **Terracotta** means "**baked earth**" and is **semi-fired ceramic clay**.
- This process makes it **waterproof and hard**, ideal for **sculpting and architectural structures**.
- Used extensively for **pottery and bricks**.

- **Bankura Horse and Terracotta temples** are famous in the **Bankura district** of **West Bengal**.
- **Buddhist viharas** from the **ancient Pala period** exhibit **terracotta art**.

Silver Crafts

- **Filigree work** is popular among **silver jewellery designers**.
- **Odisha** produces **anklets (painri, paijam)**, while **Karnataka's Bidri village** is known for **silver inlay work**.
- **Gunchi**: Unique **silver crochet decorations** are also famous.

Clay and Pottery Work

- **Clay pottery** is called the "**lyric of handicrafts**" due to its **poetic composition and sensual appeal**.
- **Mehrgarh (6000 BC)**: Earliest site showing **clay pottery** craftsmanship.
- **Painted grey ware pottery** (associated with the **Vedic period**) is a notable example.

Bronze Crafts

- **Bronze crafts** are among the oldest art forms in India, dating back over **5000 years**.
- Initially, **metals** like copper and tin were used for **weapons** such as **spears and arrows**, but later they became prominent in **art and religious objects**.
- **Bronze** was formed by **combining copper and tin**, making it a durable material for sculptures and objects.

Key Historical Insights

- The **bronze statue of the Dancing Girl** from **Mohenjodaro** (3500–3000 BCE) is one of the earliest examples of bronze craftsmanship in India.
- **Matasya Purana** contains early literary references to **bronze casting techniques**.
- **Nagarjuna's Rasa Ratnakar** discusses **metal purity** and **zinc distillation**, indicating advanced metallurgical knowledge in ancient India.

Regional Specialization in Bronze Crafts

- **Uttar Pradesh** is a leading producer of **bronze crafts** with centres in **Etawah, Sitapur, Varanasi, and Moradabad**.
 - Crafts include **decorative items** such as **flower pots** and **images of Gods and Goddesses**.
 - Known for **ritual objects** like **tamrapatra, kanchantal, and panchpatra**.
- **Tamil Nadu** produces **ancient statues** inspired by **Pallava, Chola, Pandyan, and Nayaka** art styles.

Table of Famous Bronze and Brass Crafts in India

Craft	State	Feature
Dancing Girl Statue	Mohenjodaro (Sindh, Pakistan)	One of the oldest examples of bronze art, dated between 3500 and 3000 BCE.
Flower Pots and God Statues	Uttar Pradesh (Etawah, Sitapur, Varanasi, Moradabad)	Decorative items and images of deities made from bronze.
Tamrapatra, Kanchantal, Panchpatra	Uttar Pradesh	Ritual bronze objects used in religious ceremonies.
Ancient Statues (Pallava, Chola, Pandyan, Nayaka)	Tamil Nadu	Beautiful bronze statues resembling ancient South Indian art forms.
Gaja Tandava (Shiva Statue)	Kerala	Bronze statue depicting Shiva dancing in the Tandava position .
Jain Icons and Imagery	Karnataka	Brass icons reflect the Jain pilgrim traditions of ancient Karnataka.
Dokra Casting	Odisha, West Bengal	Traditional brass ornaments were created using the lost-wax casting technique .

Pahaldar Lamps	Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh	Copper and brass lamps are made in different styles and shapes for rituals and décor.
Pembarthi Crafts	Telangana (Warangal)	Exquisite sheet metal art was used to adorn chariots and temples .

Metal Crafts

- **Metal Casting** is performed using various **metals** such as **iron, copper, bell metal**, and others.
- **Ornamentation techniques** enhance the visual appeal of metal objects, making them both functional and decorative.

Techniques of Ornamentation in Metal Crafts

- **Engraving:** Involves **etching intricate designs** onto the metal surface.
 - Commonly applied to **jewellery, utensils, and statues** to enhance their beauty.
- **Embossing:** A process where **patterns are raised** on the surface by hammering from the reverse side.
 - Often used in **decorative plates, wall hangings, and ceremonial items**.
- **Damascening:** A technique in which **gold, silver, or other metals** are inlaid into the surface of another metal.
 - Frequently used in the decoration of **weapons, jewellery, and tools**.

Marori Work – Rajasthan

- One of the most well-known techniques, originating from **Rajasthan**.
- It involves creating **etchings on the base metal** and **filling the gaps with resin**.
- **Marori work** is widely used on **decorative objects, utensils, and traditional jewelry**, showcasing fine craftsmanship.

Leather Products

- **Leather tanning** has been practised in India since **3000 BCE**.
- Initially, **tiger and deer skins** were used for tanning, but **camel leather** became the **most popular** over time.
- In **ancient times**, **rishis (wise men)** used **animal skins as mats** while living in forests.
- During the **Mughal period**, leather was widely used, but due to the **degenerative nature of leather**, **material evidence** from that period is limited.
- **Leather** is now predominantly used to manufacture **footwear, bags, and wallets**.

Regional Specialties

- **Rajasthan**
 - **Largest leather market** in India.
 - Known for **camel leather bags** of various shapes and sizes.
 - **Jaipur and Jodhpur**: Famous for **Mojadis**, a type of traditional leather footwear.
- **Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh**: Important city with a **thriving economy** based on **leather and tanned products**.
- **Maharashtra**: Known for **Kolhapuri chappals**, a traditional type of leather footwear.
- **Chennai and Kolkata**: **Major centres** for **leather bag and footwear manufacturing**.
- **Punjab**: Famous for **Punjabi juttis**, which feature **applique techniques** that enhance their attractiveness.
- **Bikaner, Rajasthan**: Known for **Manoti Art**, which involves **decorating articles with camel skin**.

Table of Famous Leather Products in India

Leather Product	State/City	Feature
Mojadis (Leather Footwear)	Jaipur and Jodhpur, Rajasthan	Traditional leather footwear with intricate designs, popular for weddings and festivals.
Kolhapuri Chappals	Maharashtra	Handmade leather sandals known for durability and unique craftsmanship.

Camel Leather Bags	Rajasthan	Bags of various shapes and sizes made from camel leather, sold in Rajasthan's large leather markets.
Leather Products (Tanned Goods)	Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh	Major centre for tanned leather products, including industrial leather and footwear.
Punjabi Juttis	Punjab	Traditional footwear featuring colorful applique work, popular in ethnic wear.
Leather Bags and Footwear	Chennai, Tamil Nadu	Important hub for manufacturing leather bags and shoes for both domestic and export markets.
Leather Bags and Wallets	Kolkata, West Bengal	Known for producing high-quality leather bags, wallets, and accessories.
Manoti Art (Decorated Camel Skin Articles)	Bikaner, Rajasthan	Leather articles decorated with camel skin, showcasing unique regional craftsmanship.

Wooden Work

- India's large forest cover provides various types of wood for **furniture, decorative items, and structures**.
- **Woodwork furniture** is made from materials like **sheesham wood, pinewood, walnut, and deodar**.
- **Kashmir** is a significant hub for **wooden furniture** and structures, using **walnut and deodar wood**.
 - Due to its **cold and wet climate**, artisans create **wooden houses, houseboats, and decorative pieces**.
 - **Kashmiri lattice work** includes:
 - **Acche-dar**
 - **Khatamband**
 - **Azlipinjra**

Table of Famous Wooden Crafts in India

Wooden Craft	State/Region	Feature
Kashmiri Lattice Work	Kashmir	Includes acche-dar, khatamband, and azlipinjra; used for furniture and architectural structures.
Wooden Furniture	Kashmir	Made from walnut and deodar wood; includes intricately carved houseboats and houses.
Wooden Latticework	Gujarat	Decorative latticework used on windows and doors.
Temple Woodcarving	Himachal Pradesh (Brahmour, Chatrahi)	Intricate carvings for temples, including naghbel, jali, and kutheriphool designs.
Sandalwood Carvings	Karnataka	Used for creating decorative items, statues, and figurines.
Red Sandalwood Dolls	Andhra Pradesh	Carved figurines and dolls from raktachandan (red sandalwood).
Teakwood Tharavad Houses	Kerala	Traditional houses made from teakwood with intricate woodwork and deep brown color.
Large Log Drums	Nagaland	Made from local wood such as kumisyng, used in traditional music and ceremonies.
Rohilda Wood Craft	Rajasthan	Decorative items like sindoor boxes and turned wooden bowls.
Lacquered Imitation Fruits	Maharashtra (Ratnagiri)	Crafted from Hale and Pangora woods, often used for decorative purposes.

Toy Making

- **Toy making** in India is both an **art form** and a **thriving business**.
- The **first evidence** of toy carts can be traced back to the **Harappan civilization** and the **early historic period**.
- **Archaeological sites** from the **Harappan period**—such as **Alamgirpur, Ambkheri, Kalibangan, and Lothal**—have revealed models of **toy carts** made from **copper, bronze, and terracotta**.
- Other **early historic sites**, including **Atranjikhera, Nagarjunakonda, Sambhar, Sonapur, Ujjain, and Brahmpuri**, also contain similar cart models.

Materials Used in Toy Making

- **Ancient and medieval toys** were crafted using various materials:
 1. **Clay**
 2. **Paper and Papier-Mâché**
 3. **Painted or Lacquered Wood**

Table of Famous Toy-Making Regions and Their Specialties

Region/State	Specialty	Feature
Andhra Pradesh	Tirupati Dolls	Made from red wood , known for their vibrant colors and intricate craftsmanship.
Kondapalli (Andhra Pradesh)	Kondapalli Toys (Ambari Hathi)	Crafted from ponki wood , Ambari Hathi is a famous toy symbolizing elephants carrying royalty.
Rajasthan	Cloth Dolls and Stuffed Animals	Brightly colored dolls and animals, often used during festivals and for decorative purposes.
Assam	Pith Dolls (Indian Cork)	Made from soft pith , these dolls reflect traditional Assamese culture .

Mysore, Karnataka	Lacquered Wooden Toys	Famous for wooden toys coated with lacquer , known for smooth finish and vibrant colors.
Chennapatna, Karnataka	Chennapatna Toys	Traditional wooden toys, also called the ' Toy Town of India ', crafted with natural dyes and lacquer.
Southern Indian States	Wooden Toys	Expertise in making toys from various woods , showcasing intricate detailing and craftsmanship.
Harappan Civilization Sites	Toy Carts (Copper, Bronze, Terracotta)	Found at Alamgirpur, Ambkheri, Kalibangan, Lothal , reflecting ancient toy-making tradition.
Early Historic Sites	Toy Carts (Various Materials)	Models found in Atranjikhhera, Nagarjunakonda, Ujjain, Sonapur, Brahmpuri , showing historical craftsmanship.

Stoneware

- **Stone masonry and crafting** is a **popular art form** in India, with a long tradition of **carving and sculpting skills**.
- During the **ancient period**, artisans used **various stones** to create **exquisite monuments** and lifelike sculptures.

Types of Stones Used

- **Soft-brittle sandstone**
- **Patchy red stone**
- **Hard granite**

Famous Stonework Examples in India

- **Mauryan Period:** Known for intricate **sculptures and architectural facades**.

- **Ajanta and Ellora Caves** (Maharashtra): Famous for **rock-cut caves** and **Buddhist sculptures**.
- **Khajuraho Temples** (Madhya Pradesh): Renowned for **erotic sculptures** carved in stone, showcasing intricate detail.
- **Buddhist Carvings at Sanchi and Bharhut** (Madhya Pradesh): Excellent examples of **religious stone carvings** from ancient India.
- **Masrur Rock-Cut Temple** (Kangra, Himachal Pradesh): **Monolithic temple** carved from a single rock, found in the **hilly region**.

Transition During the Mughal Period

- During the **Mughal period**, the focus shifted to **marble stonework**.
- **Pietra Dura Work**: Inlay work with **colourful stones** on **marble**.
 - Notable examples: **Taj Mahal** and **Itmad-ud-Daulah's Tomb** in Agra, both made of **white marble**.

Table of Famous Stonework Sites and Specialties in India

Stonework Site/Region	Type of Stone/Art	Feature
Ajanta and Ellora Caves	Rock-cut caves	Famous for Buddhist sculptures carved into rock.
Khajuraho Temples	Sandstone	Known for erotic sculptures and intricate temple carvings.
Sanchi and Bharhut	Religious stone carvings	Ancient Buddhist carvings depicting stories from Buddha's life.
Masrur Rock-Cut Temple	Monolithic rock carving	Entire temple carved from a single rock in Kangra, Himachal Pradesh .
Taj Mahal, Agra	White marble (Makrana)	Monumental marble structure with Pietra Dura inlay work , symbolizing Mughal architecture.

Itmad-ud-Daulah's Tomb	White marble	Early example of Pietra Dura inlay work in India, also called the "Baby Taj".
Rajasthan (Makrana)	Sang-e-Marmar (White marble)	Major source of white marble used in monuments like the Taj Mahal .
Jhansi, Uttar Pradesh	Sang-e Rathak (Dark brown stone)	Produces decorative and functional dark brown stone articles .

Embroidery Craft

- **Embroidery** is a **unique textile craft** that involves creating **raised designs** using **threads or wooden blocks**.
- It is performed on **cloth** using **needles** and **threads** made of **gold, silver, silk, or cotton**.

Famous Embroidery Techniques in India

- **Applique or Pipli Work**
 - **Location:** Pipli village, Odisha.
 - **Technique:**
 - A type of **patchwork** where **colourful fabric pieces** are **sewn together** to form a **single piece**.
 - Commonly used to create **decorative lamps** and other household items.
- **Phulkari Embroidery**
 - **Location:** Punjab, Haryana, and Delhi.
 - **Meaning:** Phulkari translates to "**making flowers**".
 - **Technique:**
 - Uses a **darning stitch** to form **colourful, floral-like patterns** on the cloth.
 - Traditionally used on **dupattas, shawls, and garments**.

Floor Designs - Notes

- **Floor designs** are **diverse** and can be found across **various states in India**.
- These designs are often made for **religious or family events** and **celebrations**.

- Created **freehand**, starting with a **dot in the center** that expands into **concentric patterns** of **geometrical shapes** like **circles, squares, triangles, straight lines, and curves**.
- The design evolves with **pattern repetition** from the center outward.

Table of Regional Floor Designs and Their Specialties

Floor Design	State/Region	Feature/Motif
Chowkpurna Designs	Punjab, Uttar Pradesh	Uses squares, circles, and triangles ; drawn freehand.
Aipan Designs	Himachal Pradesh	Geometric motifs such as squares, circles, and triangles .
Mandana	Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh	Includes hexagons, squares, triangles, and circles ; made with crimson red earth on cow-dung-cleaned ground.
Santhias	Gujarat	Made to decorate entrances of houses during special events.
Rangoli	Maharashtra	Features lotus, swastik , and other symbolic shapes.
Kolam (Hase, Muggulu, Golam)	Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala	Drawn with rice powder or crushed stone , outlined with red geru .
Mandapa Kolam	South India	Large floor designs created for marriage ceremonies .
Graha Kolam	South India	Drawn daily to sanctify spaces for worship in homes.
Jhonti and Aripana Designs	Odisha, West Bengal, Assam	Use of conch shells, fish, serpents, and flowers ; colored with alta and turmeric .